

EDITORIAL

ON CHAIRS WE PILE CLOTHES, WORKDAYS OR IDEAS?

Text by Manuela Ravasio – Editor-in-Chief of ELLE Italia

Now that even FOMO is no longer in fashion, what remains? With jackets, coats, bags, and frayed edges, what are we supposed to do with Fashion?

Fashion has clearly sifted through the grains of change and placed them on people's skin with fabric choices that have made us feel protected. It has ensured that we desired unnecessary objects, treating them like precious jewels simply for the sake of having them. "Beautiful Fashion" is like a Versailles that demands to be looked at, reflected in our eyes, tempting us. But it almost never comes home with us; it remains there, at the mercy of the infinite mirrors of a bygone era. The Fashion that gives satisfaction is perhaps the one we choose every day: okay, but does habit kill the magic? Should it be considered functional tailoring or Fashion? When fabrics lack revolution, Fashion becomes liquid and changes from a garment into an attitude.

For a while, in the post-lockdown era, it was fashionable to go everywhere and want to be invited everywhere—but even that is no longer a trend; quite the opposite. Today, privacy is back in fashion: the secret touch for living longer, for breathing better, for minding one's own business without scrolling. But this too will be a functional sartorial parenthesis. It's not so easy to understand what belongs to Fashion today: because both "today" and "Fashion" have taken a long break. Terms that are too overused, too burdened with containing answers they don't have.

On chairs—those clothes-hosting installations—we pile entire workdays; we gain years on our favorite jeans by patching them up; we spread miraculous creams on bags that will become cult items again in 72 months (and which, with foresight, we purchased far from the hype of the moment). Is the new gray sweatshirt that seems *more* perfect than the previous one the turning point? Is the belt never worn in forty years of life to be considered the missing comma of a lazy look? Will seven layers worn in a single combination give the satisfaction of styling? For decades, we have alternated between objects that are in fashion and attitudes that are in fashion. Walking fast in the morning? Fashion. Having dinner at seven at the very Italian Mediterranean table? Fashion. Stopping a content from going viral? Fashion. Knowing how to cook eggs in every technique in the world? Fashion. Looking at collections without ideas is something we cannot afford; covering ourselves out of necessity is an era that man should have archived; forcing ourselves into clothes and costs that do not belong to us should be a thing of the past for Fashion immediately.

There are people who surprise me greatly with their frank relationship with Fashion: I notice them, there is no strain, it is a natural act, a predisposition to understand that a garment has a much broader role in their lives than just covering limbs, and for this reason, they choose incredible pieces, not necessarily tied to uselessly stellar prices. For them, Fashion lasts longer than a click, more than a meteorological season, more than a snobbism (even that is a fashion pass-é, though a few die-hard followers remain convinced that the accessory of others is the one to give them status). In Fashion, the roads are not so infinite: and never as in this moment should they be a bit more honest. We could start by giving the right of reporting to the chairs on which we accumulate clothes: in those tangles, there are looks that are as wrong as our excellent ideas.

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AGNES VARDA'S SENSE OF THE WORLD

THE UNFORGETTABLE DIRECTOR OF *VAGABOND* WAS ALSO A CURIOUS AND SENSITIVE PHOTOGRAPHER. TWO EXHIBITIONS, IN ROME AND BOLOGNA, CELEBRATE HER GAZE.

Text by Paola Babich

«Agnès Varda was a free woman and an artist who broke with all genres, blending documentary and fiction. This, in my opinion, is her legacy, and the exhibition honoring her invites visitors to discover not only her photographic work and its links to the films that made her famous, but also the woman and the artist herself.» Speaking is Anne de Mondenard, curator at the Musée Carnavalet in Paris and co-curator, with Carole Sandrin, of *Qui e là, tra Parigi e Roma* (Here and there, between Paris and Rome), at Villa Medici in the capital (from February 25 to May 25; villa-medici.it).

This is the first major Italian retrospective dedicated to the artist's photography (1928-2019), organized among other things on the seventieth anniversary of the twinning between the two cities. It is an occasion not to be missed, accompanied by another event: the exhibition *Viva Varda!*, featuring photos, costumes, archival material, and installations, at the Galleria Modernissimo of the Cineteca di Bologna (from March 6 to February 7, 2027; cinetecadibologna.it).

At the Rome exhibition site, the work of Agnès Varda as a photographer dialogues with her work as a filmmaker through 130 original prints, film excerpts, publications, documents, posters, set photos, and objects, spanning Post-war Paris and the Italy she

traveled through in the late Fifties and early Sixties. From the images of the French capital, where she lived for over 70 years, emerges a very personal perspective, as Mondenard—who managed this section—explains. «In Paris, beyond the banks of the Seine, emblematic places of the city, Varda is particularly attracted to the environment that surrounds her: her neighborhood, her street, her courtyard-atelier on Rue Daguerre, a place of life, creation, and experimentation, but also unexpected places where most photographers would not normally go. She is interested in details that escape most people, such as caryatids, the sculptures of women on the facades of Haussmann-style buildings.»

The originality of the director and photographer is also evident in the section *L'Italia di Agnès Varda*, curated by Sandrin, which highlights the deep bonds that united her to our country through a selection of unpublished shots taken during two trips, in 1959 and 1963. «The Italy that emerges from her photographs is both picturesque and poetic, which is very consistent with what she was doing in Paris at that same time,» Sandrin emphasizes. «She doesn't pay much attention to the most popular places and monuments, but directs her gaze

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toward people and specific details of the cities—Venice, for example—or toward Italian culture, particularly Renaissance art, painting, sculpture, and music, which she appreciated immensely.»

It was during a trip to Venice that Varda created one of her famous self-portraits in front of a canvas by Gentile Bellini, playing with humor on her hairstyle, which remained a signature trait. «Her relationship with Italy, especially from the Fifties onward, remained linked primarily to figures in the film industry,» Sandrin adds. «At that time, Varda was a photographer, not yet a director; photography was the tool of her artistic expression. Nevertheless, she was already using it to identify locations or atmospheres and create reference images for her films. This is especially evident in her first feature film, *La Pointe Courte*, from 1955, so much so that in various scenes we find some of the subjects and motifs preferred in her photographic works.»

Before becoming a famous director, Varda was therefore known as a theatrical photographer and produced reportages for the press, not only French. In '63, for example, she was sent to Rome to photograph Luchino Visconti, who had just won the Palme d'Or for *The Leopard*; on that same occasion, she also visited the set of Jean-Luc Godard's *Contempt*, capturing Brigitte Bardot, Jack Palance, and Michel Piccoli with her lens. «The contact sheet (the print of the negatives, *ed.*) presented in the exhibition,» Sandrin recounts, «is a true "photographic diary" of that day when

she met Visconti and, immediately after, Godard. It also highlights the difference between the two types of photography: the commissioned portrait and the more spontaneous images taken on set.»

But there is more. Yes, because the exhibition highlights Varda's unconventional gaze, tinged with humor, her sensitivity as an attentive observer of human beings, and her constant attention to women and marginalized lives. «Agnès Varda's work is at once serious and extravagant,» Mondenard observes. «She tackles painful themes such as poverty, marginalization, and the anxieties of war and illness, expressing a genuine attention to others, but she also lets herself be carried away by unusual themes, often imbued with surrealist influences. She delighted in images and words in the same way, creating visual games.»

Beyond the artist, who was Agnès Varda the woman? «An enthusiastic person and a great worker, very creative, always reflective,» Sandrin replies. «She was curious about everything around her and nurtured a profound bond between her own imagination and the real world: she loved people, she was interested in the living conditions of women, but also in cats.» Her style is classic and, at the same time, unmistakable, depending on the photos one looks at. And despite the human being occupying an important place in her works, she was never part of the humanist photography movement. «She always fought to express herself in an independent way, especially in the film industry,» Sandrin concludes. «The legacy she leaves us is her commitment as a woman who succeeded in realizing projects from beginning to end, throughout her life, in respect of her own opinion and her own freedom.» •

IN FRONT OF AND BEHIND THE LENS Agnès Varda in a frame taken from the documentary-film *Varda by Agnès* (2019) directed by the filmmaker herself about her own life, career, and artistic journey. On page 48: The artist photographed in her courtyard-atelier on Rue Daguerre in Paris in 2018.

[Pull Quote] In '63 she was in Rome to portrait Visconti who had won the Palme d'Or for The Leopard; on the same day she went to the set of Godard's Contempt.